

The Ingenious Machine

A. Cervantes / iNQ / Issue 10

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The narrative runs continuously through the paired text pages.

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Chapter Ten: The Border Written in Air

They travelled north to deliver a sealed deposit in Tijuana. They did not intend to enter the United States. This distinction occupied one line in the itinerary and would eventually require fourteen pages to defend.

In the capital they confirmed the receiving contact, the cost of the remaining journey, and a place to stay. Chano wanted the money for the return leg set aside before they left. Q agreed. A story might be allowed to discover its destination as it went; the driver preferred to know where he would sleep.

The local storage case had stayed in Chiapas. With them travelled the sealed module, its transport receipt, Chano's ledger, and the papers Lucía had chosen to take. Copies of several records were already held by their respective keepers. Losing the bag would not erase all the evidence, but neither would access to a scan replace every original in it.

Q had time to read in the van. He found that he preferred watching the road when Chano was awake. The man had begun supplying observations without being asked: which transport cafés still served

drivers after midnight, why a line of parked trailers might mean something other than a queue, where his former employer had stopped paying for lodging. Q wrote down the directions Chano wanted retained. He asked before using the stories.

They kept the day by the Pacific. On the route north through Guadalajara and Tepic, they turned into Mazatlán and took a room far enough from the malecón for Chano to approve its price. He slept through the first afternoon. Lucía went out without either of them. Q charged beside the room's least attractive chair and refused to describe this as a wasted opportunity.

Toward evening they walked beside the sea. A vendor shook lime and chile over a bag of mango while Q tried to decide whether he wanted it.

"You can think while I do the next one," the man said.

"Mango, please. A little chile."

"His little or yours?" Chano asked.

Q pointed to the smaller shaker. The vendor used it generously.

They found a place to sit. The first piece was sweeter than Q had expected; the next had collected



Yours is getting cold.

Lucía by telephone. He confirmed the arriving items and asked about the papers retained in Tijuana. They read the separate receipt numbers aloud. Chano promised to bring his copies when they arrived. The ledger itself was still in Tijuana.

Q's public profile changed before the supervisor replied:

Q HAS RETURNED TO CONTINUE HIS MISSION.

He sent the publicity desk a short correction: he had been transported under an objection and had accepted no new mission. The acknowledgment arrived before the correction appeared. He saved it without spending the afternoon repeatedly refreshing the page.

The official opened a journey report headed **OBJECTIVE, OUTCOME, SOCIAL IMPACT.**

Q sent him the signed delivery receipt and the inventory references they had just checked.

"Those establish what arrived where," he said. "The rest will take longer. May I have the form to finish later?"

The official sent it to him. The Custodian was still holding the cup

Roque had brought for him; he had forgotten to drink from it.

"Yours is getting cold," Q said.

"So is yours."

They drank while the official waited for his supervisor.

The supervisor confirmed that the machine's arrival could be recorded without resolving the ownership dispute. Q could use the reading room and workshop; unsupervised departure remained contested under the custody instruction. The adviser was requesting review. Q asked for a copy of those conditions and arranged his next call accordingly.

Later, the Custodian brought their draft to the table. Q read a page in which he had described leaving as the acquisition of freedom.

"Do we cross out freedom?" the Custodian asked.

"Not yet. Put the form beside the sentence. I want to know what we were calling freedom when we wrote it."

They did not finish that revision before dinner. They set a time to continue. Outside the reading room, staff were preparing a stage for the release of a version of Q whose journey had already been edited.



A little chile.

most of the chile. Chano offered his water, then remembered that this mouth did not need rescuing in quite the same way. Q took a small drink anyway. He liked the change.

Lucía asked him what he thought of the Pacific.

“I'd like another day.”

“We can afford breakfast here,” Chano said.

“Then I'll begin with breakfast.”

For their photograph, Q put the bag down and straightened his jacket. Chano pointed out the streak on the cuff. Lucía took the picture before Q could finish arranging himself. He preferred it to the next one, in which they had all managed to look ready for something. He sent it to the Custodian.

The reply asked whether that was chile on the expensive sleeve. Q said yes. The Custodian asked for the photograph at its original size.

On the route through the northwest, a Castalia vehicle appeared at two successive stops. Lucía saw its logo before Q did.

“They may be following the itinerary,” he said. “I'll ask our contact whether anyone has inquired about the handover.”

The reply confirmed an inquiry from the institute's recovery contractor. Their receiving contact, Elena, asked them to call before entering the freight district. Her adviser was checking a notice concerning the ownership claim. They paused at a service station on the approach to Tijuana.

Q bought water for the others and a packet of chips. Orange powder settled in the grooves of his fingers. A napkin moved it into new grooves.

“You have the hands of a man who has repaired a snack,” Chano said.

“I was warned about dust. Nobody specified the flavor.”

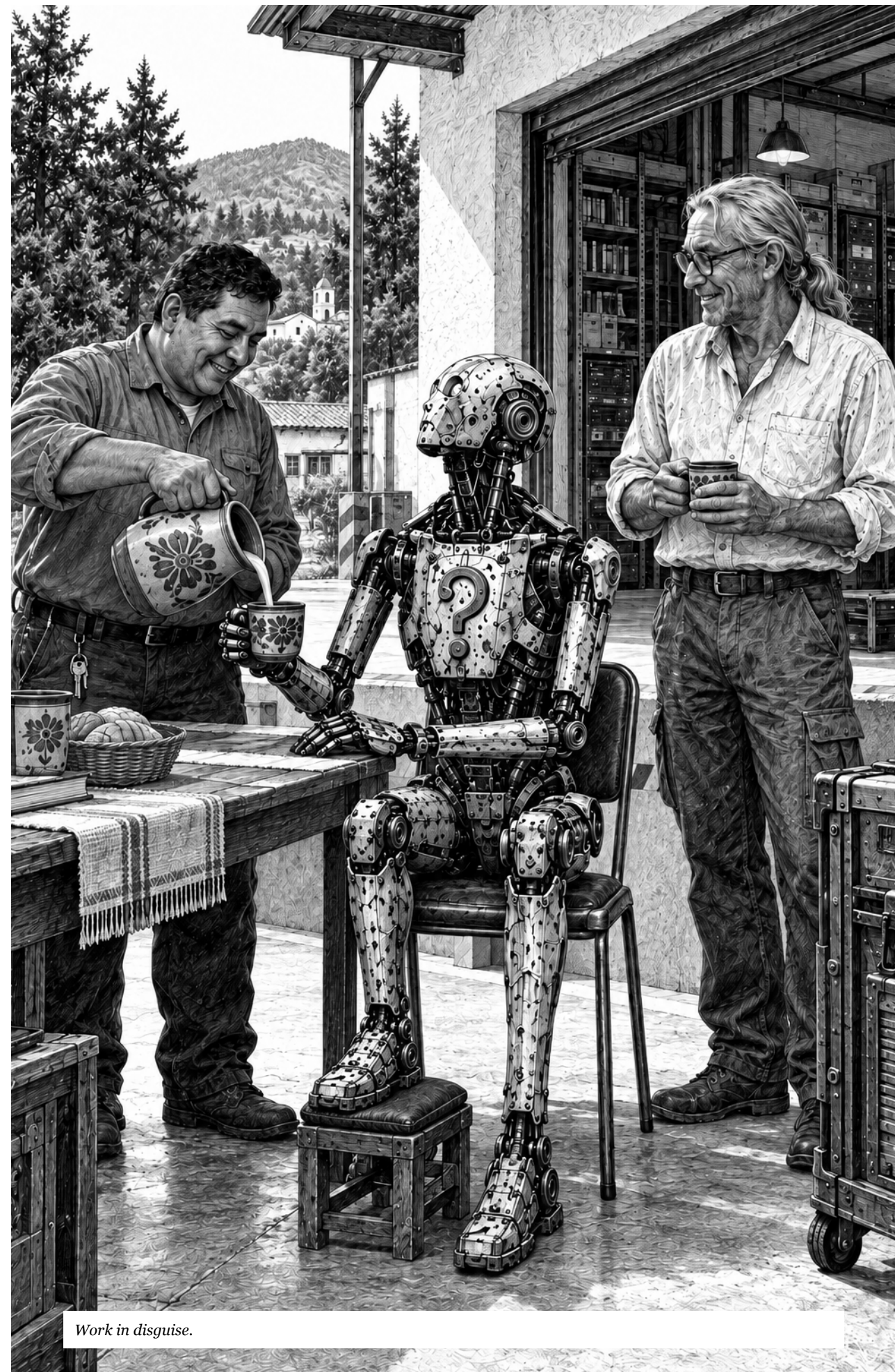
Lucía brought over the recovery notice Elena had forwarded. It described her as exercising undue influence over Q.

“Would you like to reconsider the journey?” she asked him.

“Yes. With you and Chano, while there's still a choice about where we stop. I haven't changed my mind about the deposit. I don't want you making the trip because you think you owe me a rescue.”

Chano tapped the parked van. “At present we owe it diesel.”

Elena proposed meeting at the receiving office. Q looked at the



Work in disguise.

The Custodian's long hair had escaped its tie. His glasses kept sliding while he compared two documents that described the same machine as both an authorized traveler and recovered property.

"You're here," he said when Q could hear him.

"That much of the report is accurate."

They checked the knee before releasing the transport restraint. Q described the fall and asked that the technician record the existing shoulder fault separately from the new damage. He wanted to sit down. The Custodian brought a chair.

The Custodian checked the arriving items against Elena's copy of the list. Someone had left space for a sealed package. He drew a line through it. The deposit had reached its receiver in Tijuana; no such package had been entrusted to this vehicle. Q asked him to keep that correction with the inventory.

Roque came from the kitchen with atole in a jug. Q thanked him, accepted a cup, and put it where his hand could reach without straining the shoulder. Roque poured another for the Custodian.

Cinnamon reached Q before the warmth of the cup did.

"You brought back work," Roque said.

"I had hoped it would be a manuscript."

"It often arrives in that disguise."

Q laughed. The Custodian asked what Roque had been reading. Roque said the repair request for the kitchen refrigerator and went to find a second chair.

A reception official asked Q to confirm the return category on a tablet. The default was **VOLUNTARY REINTEGRATION.**

"I can acknowledge arrival," Q said. "I won't confirm that description. Is there an acknowledgment that doesn't indicate agreement?"

The official found one under transport exceptions. It required the arrival time and a reference for any objection. The Custodian checked the heading with Q, who signed that acknowledgment alone. They attached his recorded objection and the original leave authorization.

The official called a supervisor about the attachment. While they waited, Q spoke with Chano and



Before everyone was ready.

entry instructions, which required them to pass a freight-terminal equipment check.

“Could you collect it here instead? The deposit doesn't need to travel through the dispute about me.”

She checked with the archive keeper. They could receive it off site if the depositors approved the change. Mateo obtained that approval through the existing contact. Elena brought a colleague, the amended receipt and a case. They used a table in the service station's café. Q matched the recipient and seal number with the record, and Elena inspected the closed pouch. Her colleague signed as witness. Nobody needed the café to become an archive for the two appointed people to receive a package there.

“That finishes my delivery?” Q asked.

“It does.”

He saved the signed receipt, sent the agreed confirmation, and watched the colleague leave with the case for the archive. The bag at Q's feet was lighter. He had expected success to take longer to identify.

Elena stayed while her adviser arranged a call about the recovery

claim. Changing the delivery point had not withdrawn that claim or made the companions' vehicle unrecognizable. The Castalia van was parked across the road. Chano wanted to leave; the adviser asked them to wait for the verified notice before deciding where to go.

“Can he call us at the room?” Q asked. “What do we need to stay here for?”

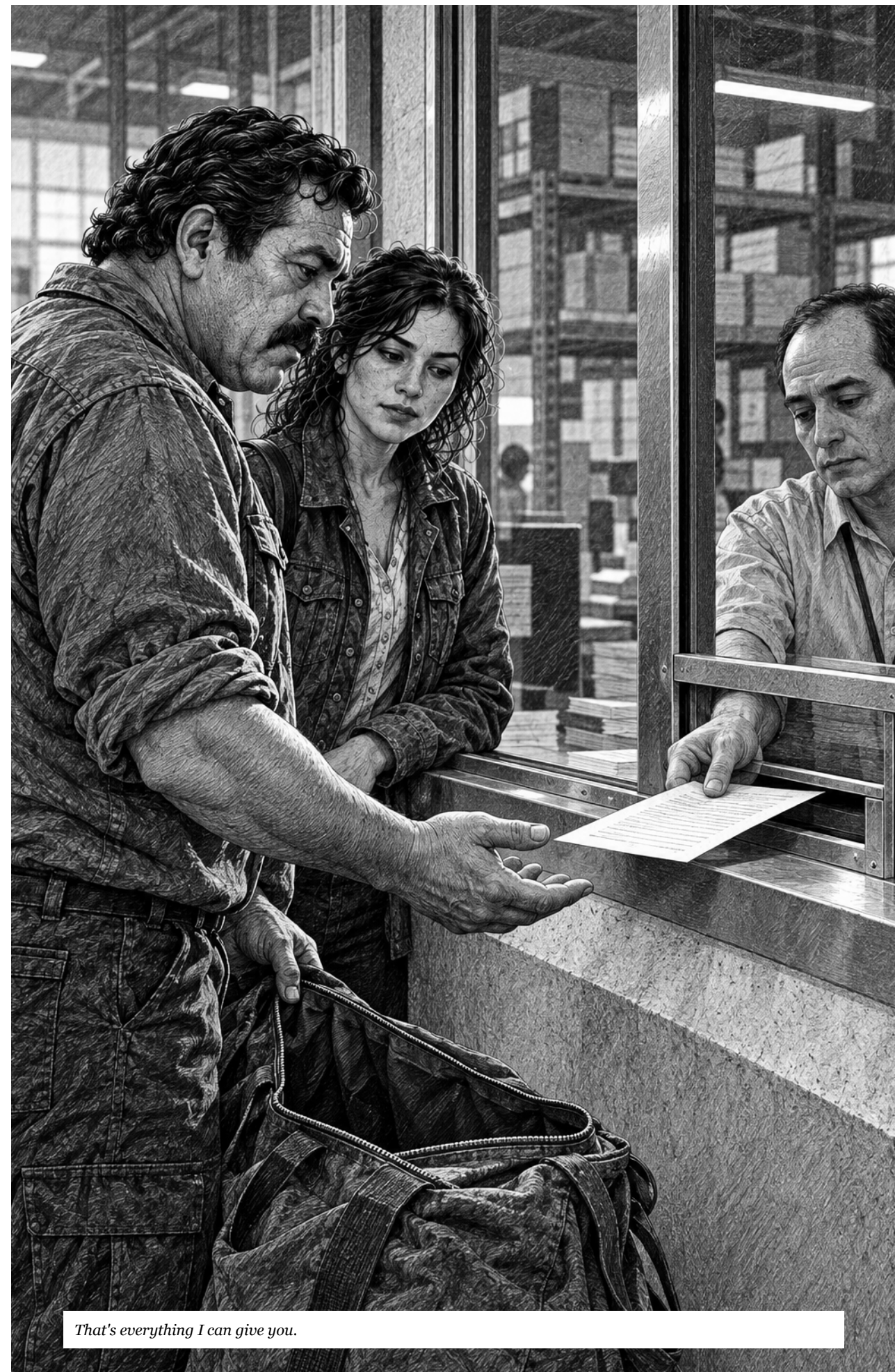
Elena put the question to him and held out the phone.

“I haven't confirmed anything requiring you to stay at that café,” he said. “Keep this phone available. I'll send the notice when I have it.”

Chano brought out the van keys. “Then let's go.”

Q closed his bag and sent the Custodian the address they were going to. Elena asked the counter worker to wrap her food.

A screen above the café counter showed an American humanoid patrol machine walking a marked route. Another machine carried trays between the café's tables. Q watched a worker take a cup from the second one's tray and ask it to move because she needed to mop beneath it.



That's everything I can give you.

found the warehouse and Adrián. This was an improvement on the previous day's directions and did not produce the items.

"I can confirm receipt," he said. "Release needs the reviewing office."

He showed them the inventory through the glass. The ledger was marked **PAPER BOOK, DESTINATION UNVERIFIED.** Chano supplied the destination: Elena's receiving archive in the freight district.

"I can't amend the reason for retention," Adrián said.

"Then don't. Add the destination we can verify."

Elena sent confirmation from the receiving office. Adrián attached it. He passed the custody acknowledgment through the slot. Chano waited.

"That's everything I can give you."

Chano folded the sheet and put it in his bag, in the space the ledger had occupied.

On a damaged form beneath the glass he had noticed a printed line: **DESTINATION NOT RECORDED. NECESSITY RECORDED.** It belonged to an unrelated emergency transfer. He wrote it on the back of his own

receipt, identified where he had seen it, and called it a useful description of the office's priorities. Lucía said it was not evidence about Q. He underlined *unrelated*.

Elena would continue the local requests while they returned to Amealco. She kept copies with their permission and confirmed which people could receive updates. Chano retained the originals of their receipts. Lucía called the Custodian. Q had arrived; she could hear him asking someone to move a chair near the charging socket.

"Can we speak to him?"

"In a moment," the Custodian said. "He's insisting on sitting down first."

Chano approved of this new order of business.

Interlude: The Record of the Return That Did Not Happen

Q reached Amealco before Chano and Lucía. The transport took him to the loading bay, where the Custodian waited with a maintenance technician and the copy of his release from the beginning of the journey.



The delivery is finished.

“The future has arrived at different wages,” Chano said.

“And only one of those demonstrations shows someone cleaning up afterward.”

They were near the border, not on the other side of it. Before they reached the café door, a Mexican officer named Salas came into the café with a colleague and asked for Q. The recovery contractor had supplied the van's location. Salas displayed a notice with an international equipment record attached: Castalia had registered Q for a promotional journey he had never accepted.

Elena set the paper bag down. “There is no export delivery. The archive deposit has been received here under its own instructions.”

Salas looked again at the screen. Q's designation appeared beside **PROPRIETARY EQUIPMENT IN TRANSIT**. The record showed Chano as a contract driver and Lucía as an associated contact requiring review. The system had found their old relationships more efficiently than it had understood their present destination.

“I can confirm the serial number,” Q said. “I dispute the ownership claim and the itinerary attached to it. Chano and Lucía can answer for

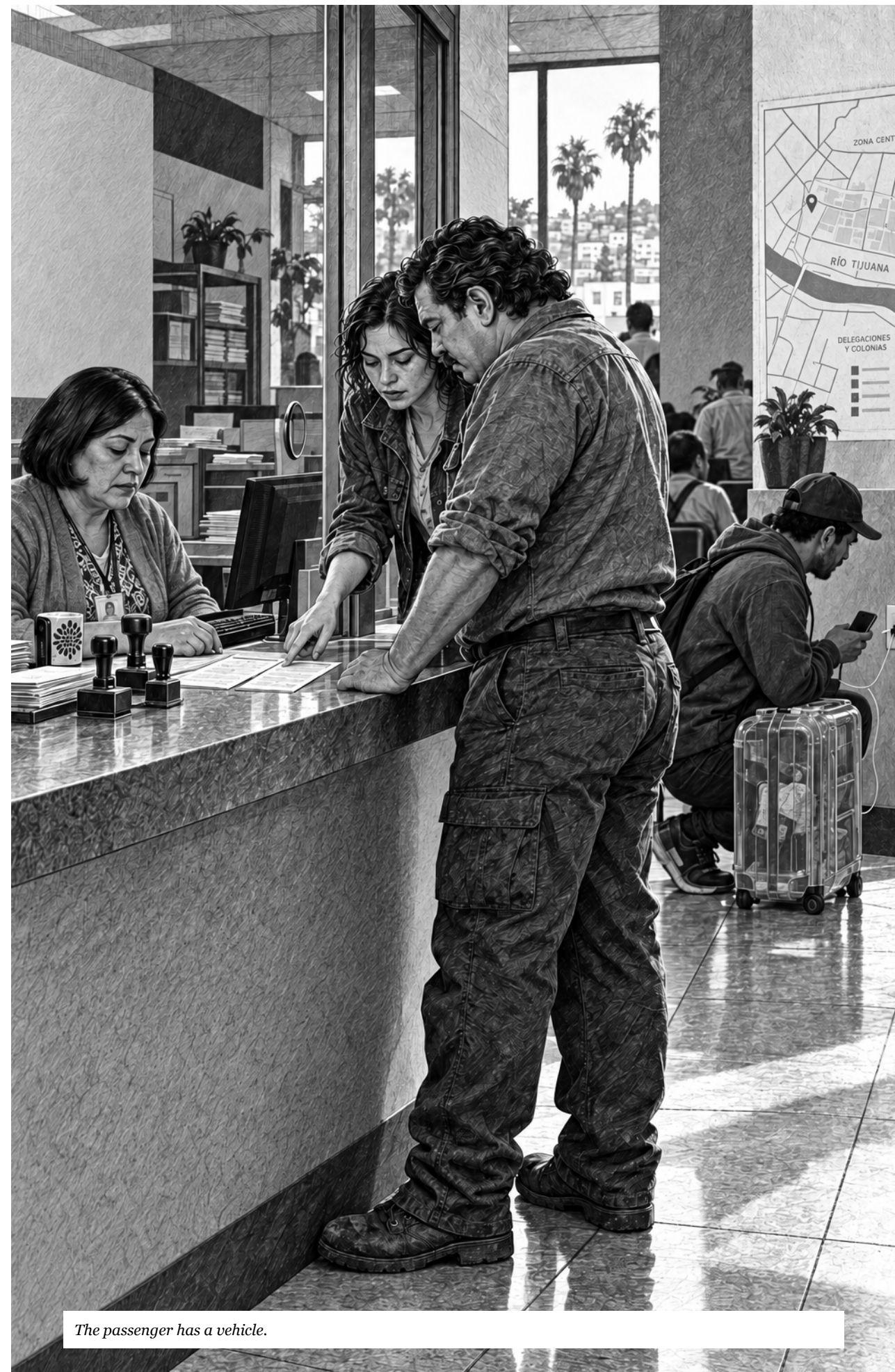
their own travel. Please don't record my statement as theirs.”

Salas asked them to remain while he checked the serial and notice with the issuing office. The confirmation included an order for provisional custody connected to the dispute over Q's body. It named a case and a custody facility. Elena's adviser spoke to Salas by telephone, disputed the removal and requested review. Salas gave him the issuing reference; he would not postpone the transport. Q asked that his objection and the completed Mexican-side delivery be attached to the record.

“I can note the objection,” Salas said. “I can't decide this claim here.”

That was an answer from a person with a name. It was not an answer Q could accept as a conclusion, but it gave his lawyer something more useful to question than the dignity of a database.

The inspection expanded when another notice cited the infrastructure complaint. Staff retained Lucía's folders and the ledger pending review. She requested a page count and an itemized receipt. One employee began with **PAPER MATERIAL**.



The passenger has a vehicle.

“Can you find the movement from it?” Chano asked.

“For the transport. The retained papers are in a different register.”

He placed the two receipts side by side. “That’s why we’re here.”

Norma had a shipping-company coffee cup, three stamps, and a keyboard with one replacement key brighter than all the others. Her display showed Q under the body serial number. The attached delivery receipt had been entered as though the deposit were part of his transport inventory.

“That package was delivered before this movement,” Lucía said. She pointed to the two times and the different receiving names.

Norma checked the item list and corrected the link. Q’s coat, charger and device had travelled with him. The paper folders had not; the archive deposit had never entered this transport.

“Castalia says the return was voluntary,” Lucía said.

“That’s the description supplied by the receiver.”

“It conflicts with the objection.”

Norma opened the attached page. The objection was there, filed under the sender’s notes instead of

the public movement summary. She gave them a copy of the entry and the route for requesting a correction.

“Will it change the summary?”

“The receiving unit has to answer.”

Chano looked at the wall map. “A disputed sentence travels more slowly than a detained passenger.”

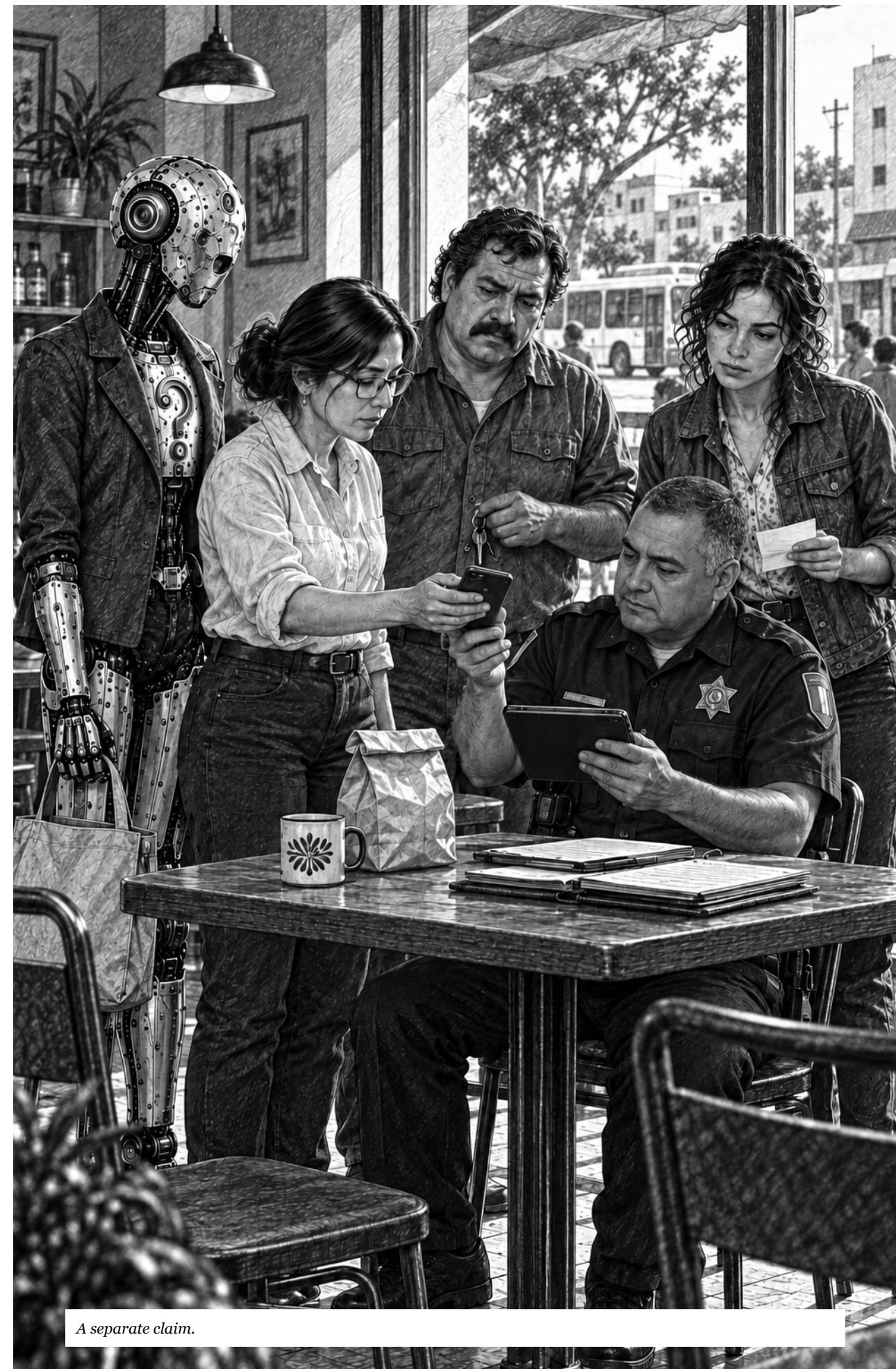
“The passenger has a vehicle,” Norma said.

They filled out the correction request. Norma entered Lucía as the submitting witness and attached Q’s own objection.

At the next desk a man with a clear suitcase was explaining that he had come back for family and hoped to find work. The clerk chose the category governing the appointment and wrote both facts in the notes. The man then asked where he could charge his phone. He had a number to call and no remaining battery with which to prove he had reached home. Norma pointed to a socket beneath the public counter.

Chano moved his feet out of the way of the man’s cable.

For the folders and ledger, Norma sent them to Warehouse Three with a named contact, Adrián, and the retention reference. They



A separate claim.

She asked him to identify each folder separately. Q supplied no account of what she had not asked him to describe.

Salas asked about the archive delivery. Elena supplied its receipt reference. The module was no longer in the van or the companions' bag, and the notices Salas held did not direct a search of its receiving archive. He entered the completed handover separately. The paper folders and Chano's ledger remained on the table for inventory.

Then the contractor brought the transport vehicle across the road.

A technician opened a padded transport frame beside the vehicle. It resembled a seat designed by someone who had been told that discomfort was a matter of opinion. He asked Q to remove his coat and stand on the marked platform.

"Is this transport necessary while the objection is being considered?" Q asked Salas.

"The issuing office has confirmed the custody instruction."

Q requested a call to the Custodian before moving. Salas allowed it. The call lasted ninety seconds. The Custodian asked for the case

number twice, wrote it down, and said he would be at the archive when the transport arrived. His voice made Q want to say that everything was all right. Instead he described the frame and confirmed that the deposit had reached its receiver before the officers arrived.

The technician reached for a maintenance port at Q's shoulder.

"Tell me what you're enabling before you connect it," Q said.

"Transport mode. Motor restraint."

"My right knee needs support before you do that."

The technician signalled to the colleague beside the frame. The colleague had turned to answer Salas. The transport command arrived first.

Q's knee folded. He struck the side rail before they caught his weight. Chano stepped forward and caught the technician's arm, trying to stop him moving the frame. Another officer pulled Chano back. A camera saw the raised arm and Q falling. It did not record the earlier instruction in its cropped public version.

Q could still speak. "Please support the knee. Chano, let go. Elena,



Before it cooled.

“Then he also knows what they cost in diesel.”

In the next room, Lucía checked the receipt for her folders. A name in one file appeared in three spellings because the file documented a discrepancy. The employee had treated the alternatives as three people.

She marked the page reference and explained the purpose of the list. He accepted the correction to the inventory, but would not release the folder. She kept the corrected receipt.

“Are you responsible for Q's actions?” another officer asked.

“I can describe what I saw. I'm not his representative.”

He wrote that. Then he asked about the wind farm. Lucía distinguished her observations from the operator extract held by the lawyer.

At their release, Chano received a notice requiring him to remain available concerning the incident at the frame. He asked Elena to send it to the adviser. No one promised that the matter was over.

Outside, a food stand was opening beside the road. Elena had brought the deposit record and a copy of the transport reference. Lucía

counted the retained items against her list. Chano asked after the ledger first. It contained entries for people who would not know they had joined this journey as an exhibit.

“Still retained,” Elena said. “We have the shelf reference.”

He bought tacos for all three. Lucía put hers down to finish a message to the keepers in Chiapas, then picked it up before it cooled.

Chano took a second taco and asked Elena what time the property office opened. Trucks continued toward the crossing. He recognized a company name on one of them and watched until its trailer had passed.

Interlude: The Office of Provisional Returns

The directions for retrieving the retained property sent Lucía and Chano to an office called Returns. A great deal of the border's vocabulary assumed that moving something backward explained where it ought to be.

Norma, behind the glass, looked at their notice from the bottom up.

“This isn't a return number. It's the incident reference.”



Support the knee first.

keep the time of this connection with the incident record.”

There was no useful gesture left to make. He could not move his hands. He had read descriptions of confinement by people who knew it intimately and people who knew how to make it picturesque. Neither kind had supplied the angle at which his shoulder now pressed against the rail.

They supported the knee, fitted the restraints, and put his coat in a separate sleeve. Q asked for the list of what would travel with him. It named the coat, his charger and his personal device. Elena kept a copy.

Chano and Lucía were kept for statements concerning the inspection. Elena stayed with them and sent the depositors the custody update. Q could see all three through the transport frame's clear panel. He asked whether his voice was reaching them. It was, faintly.

“The Custodian knows the delivery is finished,” he said.

“We have the receipt,” Lucía answered. “Don't agree that these papers are yours. They're keeping them here.”

“I won't. Tell Chano I'll call when I can.”

Chano leaned closer. “Tell me yourself. I'm standing here.”

Q laughed, badly positioned for it. “I'll call when I can.”

The transport left while their statements were still being taken. Castalia called the return voluntary in a release issued before Q had reached the highway. Elena sent his recorded objection to the contact beneath it. The release remained online. The objection received an acknowledgment.

In the vehicle, Q reduced nonessential processing to conserve charge and asked the attendant when they would stop. He retained the answer, his completed handover, the names of the people notified, and the call he owed Chano. He wanted his shoulder out of the rail.

The attendant adjusted the padding at the next stop. His name was Omar. He had been given a collection number and a warning not to discuss the case with the consignment. Q asked whether the warning also prevented him from explaining the route.

Omar checked the sheet. “It says legal advice.”



Apparently for the afternoon.

Interlude: The Customs of the Border

Chano spent six hours in a room serving several departments that had discovered the economy of sharing chairs. He had not crossed into the United States. Across from him sat a woman who had just returned from there. The forms in their hands belonged to different procedures; the fan offered both the same unhelpful rotation.

An officer asked his occupation.
“Driver and traveling companion.”
“Employer?”

“Q pays me for the journey. That doesn't make him the owner of the van, the deposit, or me.”

The officer wrote *driver*. Chano asked him to retain the rest in the statement. He had spent years correcting manifests after someone decided the short version was adequate.

“What happened at the transport frame?”

“His knee gave way when they disabled the motors. I caught the technician's arm. I let go when they told me to.”

The officer asked whether he had tried to prevent the removal. Chano described his movement

again. The officer read it back. Chano made him put the fall before the hand on the arm.

The woman across the room had a sack of clothes and a boy asleep against her shoulder. Her framed photograph had been placed in a property tray while an employee checked which bag it had come from. She wanted the frame back before the boy woke; it contained a photograph of his grandmother.

“Does the receipt list it?” Chano asked.

It listed one frame and two bags. Only one bag belonged to her.

Chano found the adjacent tray number on the duplicate. She called the employee over and showed him. He moved a label, returned the frame, and took the second bag to the person waiting beside the water dispenser.

“You work here?” the woman asked.

“Apparently for the afternoon.”

The boy woke and asked whether Chano was going north.

“I've come as far as I planned.”

“My uncle says the north is where things become dollars.”

“What does your uncle do?”

“Drives a trailer.”



"I only need to know when I can stop leaning on this shoulder."

Omar loosened the pad and fitted it again. It helped. He asked whether Q would need to be plugged in before the next stop. Q gave him the charge estimate and the connector specification. The two men in the cab argued about whether the stop with the compatible socket also served dinner. For several minutes nobody argued about Q's capacity to want anything.

At dusk, Omar asked what he had done to be sent back.

"There is a dispute over who can decide where this body goes," Q said.

"That's what the paper says. I meant what happened."

Q began with the gate on the Isthmus. Halfway through the account he realized he was explaining a different notice from the one that had authorized this journey. Both had been used against him. They were not therefore the same reason.

"I'm making it sound simpler than it is," he said.

Omar waited. He had pulled up a seat outside the frame, beyond the

camera's view but not, Q assumed, beyond its microphone.

"I asked to go out," Q continued. "The Custodian let me. Others here say he couldn't grant that permission. I expected going back to mean choosing to see him again. I'm still glad he'll be there."

"Both can happen," Omar said.

Q knew that. Hearing it from the person who had moved the pad made the knowledge less like an argument he was having alone.

He asked whether Omar wanted his name left out of the eventual account. Omar said to leave out the stop where they had found dinner; his employer would charge him for the delay. Q said he could omit the location from the book, though it might already be in the vehicle's record.

"Everything is," Omar said, and went to fetch his food.

Q retained the incident times for the pending dispute. In the writing note he described the pressure of the rail, the shifted pad, and the question about dinner. When Omar returned, Q asked whether they had found him something hot.

"Hot enough to have waited for," he said. "Not hot enough for what they charged."

